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Does the “happy-productive worker” thesis apply to managers?

The “happy-productive worker” thesis

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Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this paper is to emanate from an enduring stream of research into individual performance and organisational productivity where happy employees are believed to perform better. Decades of research have been unable to establish a strong link between workplace happiness and performance. A variation on the enduring employee happiness-productivity debate is evolving the “happy-performing managers” proposition.

Design/methodology/approach – An empirical investigation reports on the impact of two important aspects of job happiness – self-rated affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction – on superiors’ ratings of managers’ contextual and task performance. An ancillary methodological objective of the study is to establish the structure of managers’ performance.

Findings – A partial model of managers’ affective wellbeing, intrinsic job satisfaction and performance contributed an understanding to how specific indicators of affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction predict certain dimensions of managers’ performance.

Practical implications – Changes in the workplace emphasises are needed to ensure managers can retain and improve their positive affective wellbeing by working smarter and faster, rather than harder and longer.

Originality/value – A contribution of this paper is to provide qualified support for the “happy-performing managers” proposition by linking the conceptual bases relating to managers’ affective wellbeing, intrinsic job satisfaction and to their performance. These findings progress the debate as to how work might be structured to improve managers’ affective wellbeing and consequently their performance. Perhaps, it is timely to consider moving away from the negative forms of psychology and affirm managers’ future by embracing the “happy-performing managers” proposition.

Keywords Managers, Job satisfaction, Productivity rate, Employee productivity

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

In the new millennium, happiness in the workplace is well and truly back in vogue. There has been an explosion of research and proselytising into happiness, optimism and positive character traits. What is driving this renewed interest into employees’ and managers’ job happiness and performance? In the twenty-first century, effective managers’ performance is even more central to the success of organisations. Pressures to manage within these increasingly complex local, national and global workplace dynamics are greater than ever before. In these circumstances successful organisations are dependent on managers’ capacity to achieve and maintain high levels of individual job performance.



Managers are now expected to perform in a business context where significantly increased performance is demanded. These circumstances have given rise to a generation of managers who are both “time poor” and “wellbeing poor”. Eventually, declines in managers’ performance will hamper the capacity of organisations and national economies to create wealth. As a consequence, predictors of improvement or deterioration on managers’ performance, such as happiness, are critical to the success of organisations. These changes in the workplace emphasise the need to understand how managers can retain their positive affective wellbeing by working smarter and faster, rather than harder and longer.

The “happy-productive worker” thesis

Few conundrums have captured and held the imagination of organisational researchers and practitioners as has the “happy-productive worker” thesis. Proponents of this idea are convinced that “a happy worker is a good worker”. Support for this “commonsense theory” (Fisher, 2003) is based on the belief that happy workers are believed to perform better than their unhappy co-workers (Cropanzano and Wright, 1999, 2001; Wright and Cropanzano, 1997, 2000; Wright *et al.*, 2002). Notwithstanding the general support for the presumed “happy-productive worker” link, decades of research have been unable to establish a close link between employees’ happiness and their performance. Perhaps, the “happy-productive worker” thesis is a self-sustaining “urban myth”, founded in opinion but lacking empirical support. Evidence provided by Hosie *et al.* (2006) suggests otherwise.

A variation on this enduring debate is undertaken here into the happiness-productivity theme, to investigate the “happy-performing managers” proposition. The emphasis was on investigating an aspect of human behaviour with the potential to enhance managerial performance. A comprehensive examination is undertaken into the impact of two important aspects of happiness in the workplace – affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction – on managers’ contextual and task performance. An important shift in addressing this age old debate is evolving the “productive worker” thesis into the “performing managers” proposition.

The “happy-performing managers” proposition

The metamorphosis of the “happy-productive worker” thesis into the “happy-performing managers” proposition is determined by the need to focus on managers’ performance in the workplace. As a butterfly is not simply a better caterpillar, the construct “managers’ performance” is likewise different to “workers’ productivity”. As such, a manager is not simply an improved worker but is differentiated by a more complex array of roles and responsibilities informed by the function of contextual and task performance.

The veracity of the “happy-performing managers” proposition is investigated to establish if the affect/satisfaction-performance relationship applies to managers. From a broader perspective this discourse is also intended to contribute to the debate over what underpins human performance at work. Findings about employees’ affective wellbeing, intrinsic job satisfaction and performance also apply to managers who are invariably employees in some form. The findings and observations made in this paper explain the “happy-performing managers” proposition and how this intersects with the needs of organisations. The challenge is to reorientate our thinking to utilise modes

of managers' performance which are relevant and realistic for individual and organisational success.

Comprehensive and robust evidence was found by Hosie *et al.* (2006) to support the existence of a definite but specific relationship between managers' job-related affective wellbeing, intrinsic job satisfaction and performance. Specific indicators of affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction were found to be reliable predictors of certain dimensions of managers' contextual and task performance. Insights are supplied into how positive affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction are related to enhanced managerial performance, whereas conversely, poor affective wellbeing indicates diminished performance. In addition, the structure and substance of managers' contextual and task performance is conceived and measured to a standard previously unachievable. These findings need to be conceived of within the re-emergence of the general interest in happiness.

The "happy-productive worker" thesis

Happiness is back in town

In January 2005, *Time* magazine published an entire issue on the "New Science of Happiness". Philosophers, neuroscientists, pharmacologists, political scientists, geneticists, linguists and all manner of "new age" gurus are contributing to this timely dialogue on happiness in the workplace. Likewise, *The Economist* featured "Happiness (and how to measure it)" in the Leaders section in December 2006/January 2007 issue. Seldom has an academic quest come into play so quickly and so deliberately.

Curiously, most interest about happiness is being generated at the edges of the two "dismal sciences" of economics and psychology. The worlds of this "dreary duo" converged in 2002, when the Nobel Prize for Economics was awarded for the first time to a psychologist. Princeton Professor Daniel Kahneman received the laurel for investigating a phenomenon known as the "hedonic treadmill" which explains why money can buy happiness but does not continue to keep people happy (Bagnall, 2004). Economists of various persuasions are now furiously devising equations for putting a dollar value on the stuff that relates to happiness.

London School of Economics Professor Lord Layard (2005), author of *Happiness: Lessons from a New Science*, provides evidence of the relationship between increasing wealth and decreasing happiness in the developed world. Layard contends that economic growth does not automatically increase social harmony. Instead, Layard argues for the unpopular position that increased taxes can improve the work-life balance of citizens and increase overall wellbeing in a society. Likewise, Martin (2005) argues that people are not always motivated by financial incentives at work, and in some cases, he claims that financial incentives can actually reduce motivation instead of increasing it!

Layard and Martin both pay homage to Bentham, the revered eighteenth century utilitarian philosopher. Bentham (1776) argued that the purpose of public policy should be to maximise the sum of happiness in society, as expressed by the famous utilitarian doctrine of "the greatest happiness for the greatest number". This assertion led economists to focus on the utility of happiness which is assumed to be measurable and comparable across people. Noted economists of the late twentieth century, such as Paul Samuelson in the USA, and John Hicks from the UK, spawned the movement to transform economics into a "hard science".

An unfortunate consequence of this fundamental shift in direction of thinking was that it encouraged economists to abandon the “pursuit of happiness” for the more narrow “pursuit of wealth”. Increased personal wealth was naively assumed to lead to enhanced individual happiness. In the process, a mythical rational being, the “economic man [sic]” was created in an attempt to help economists deal with their dark quantitative condition of “physics envy”. In a *History of Happiness in Economics*, Bruni (2005) alerts us to the economists’ long held misunderstanding that all humans are rational beings who find happiness in maximising their personal utility. Clearly, happiness is back on the public policy agenda. Some devilish elements in popular media have also picked up on the interest in wellbeing in the workplace.

Stress is no laughing matter

Squeezing the pips – $1/2 \times 2 \times 3$ – whereby half as many people are being paid twice as much, to produce three times more (Handy, 1996).

Interest in employee affective wellbeing has reached the level of public recognition where parodies are beginning to emerge. An amusing but somewhat disturbing example is Edwards’s (2004) satirical book, *Stress in the Workplace – How to Cause it*. In the foreword, Edwards posits that mental anguish is the precursor to productivity and claims to have exploded the myth that a “happy company is a productive one”. Inventive and imaginative ways are provided in his book to ensure that employees will reach their full potential in a work environment that is “bereft of comfort and languor”. Fierce competition between employees is argued to be a great motivator, and those who feel good are berated for being too placid. Edwards’s tongue-in-cheek position reverses contemporary advice about the preference and desirability of harmonious workplaces.

In Williamson’s (2005) play *Influence*, Ziggy Blasko, a “shock-jock” radio announcer poses the question, “Stress – we all have stress in our lives. So what’s new?” Ziggy is enraged by this “stress is bad talk”, angrily proclaiming that, “All this rubbish about stress and depression is just a way to keep thousands of so-called mental health gurus making a good living”. Another pertinent example comes from the television series *The Office* (Gervais and Merchant, 1995). The central character is David Brent, the “boss from hell” who is a “legend in his own lunchbox” who is portrayed as an overtly happy manager who specialises in facilitating a cheerful working environment by being an “entertaining manager”. He delights in telling gratuitous off-colour jokes and is blissfully unaware of the effect of this obnoxious behaviour on those around him. Despite the obvious misery wreaked on his hapless employees, Brent is convinced he is performing exceptionally well as a manager by using a self-professed skill as “professional entertainer” to create a happy working environment.

Maybe the unpalatable reality for workers is the realisation that miserable managers, who adopt oppressive work practices, are just as effective as happy ones! Fortunately this position flies in the face of the evidence that overbearing attitudes, appalling communications and toxic personalities all have a major negative effect on employee motivation and morale. Certainly, evidence in this paper provides a clear positive link between managers’ happiness and their performance.

This exploratory study investigated if there is an association between managers’ job-related affective wellbeing (“affective wellbeing”), intrinsic job satisfaction and their contextual and task performance (“managers” performance). Specifically, the main goal

of this research was to establish which indicators of managers' affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction predict dimensions of their performance. A substantial research question was revisited – what is the impact of affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction on managers' performance? Answering this question required the development of a new instrument for measuring managers' performance, and also the differentiation of the construct of affective wellbeing from intrinsic job satisfaction.

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Methodology

A number of research questions and hypotheses derived from the extant literature were investigated in this paper. An empirical methodology was used to test the hypotheses to enable the research questions to be answered and to develop an estimated partial model of managers' affective wellbeing, intrinsic job satisfaction and performance (partial model) as shown in Figure 1 to explain the link between affective traits and states, intrinsic job satisfaction and performance.

A series of hypotheses were developed to test a flow model of managers' affective wellbeing, intrinsic job satisfaction and performance suitable as presented in Figure 1. A questionnaire was administered to 19 Western Australian organisations to collect cross-sectional data to answer the research question, test the hypotheses and develop the partial model. Data was collected using self-report measures of affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction, and downward appraisal of managers' performance (by the person to whom managers reported). A composite selection of private, public and “third sector” organisations was surveyed, representing managers from a range of occupational groups. A total of 400 useable questionnaires were returned from the 1,552 distributed, representing a 26 per cent useable response rate.

During the literature review it became apparent that there were a considerable number of well-validated instruments for measuring affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction, but few that were suitable for collecting data on variables identified as determining behavioural outcomes of managers' performance. Questionnaire items were obtained from established published scales for job-related affective wellbeing (Sevastos, 1996; Watson and Clark, 1992) and intrinsic job satisfaction (Cook *et al.*, 1981; Sevastos, 1996). These instruments were acceptable for measuring state and trait affective wellbeing and managers' performance. The affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction scales were compared and evaluated before selecting those suitable for multivariate analysis. Both of these scales were suitable for measuring managers' affective wellbeing in relation

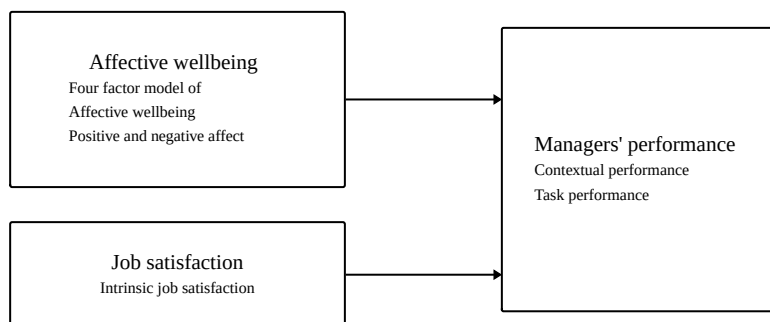


Figure 1.
Estimated partial model of
managers' affective
wellbeing, intrinsic job
satisfaction and
performance

to their contextual and task performance. In particular, the scales were more theoretically congruent with the notion of job “happiness” (Sevastos, 1996; Warr, 1994, 2007).

Managers’ contextual and task performance scales were devised from the literature. Two types of performance are distinguished in the literature: contextual and task (Borman and Motowidlo, 1993; Motowidlo and Schmit, 1999). Both domains of performance contribute to accomplishing organisational goals, but through different mechanisms. Managers’ performance mainly constitutes task performance, which is defined as the:

[...] effectiveness with which job incumbents perform activities that contribute to its technical core either by directly implementing a part of its technological process, or by providing it with needed materials or services (Motowidlo *et al.*, 1997).

Contextual performance deals with the psychological linkages between people and is represented by discretionary forms of contributions to the organisation that have uncertain or indirect rewards compared to task performance (Organ and Paine, 1999). No suitable validated measures of managers’ performance were identified in the literature necessitating the development of an instrument to measure the structure of managers’ contextual and task performance. Generic behaviour dimensions were included from the literature (Borman and Brush, 1993; Konovsky and Organ, 1996; Organ and Lingl, 1995; Podsakoff *et al.*, 1990; Quinn *et al.*, 1996).

Self-report data were used to measure affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction, while superiors’ ratings (by the person to whom managers report) provided an evaluation of managers’ contextual and task performance.

Methods

Concepts, constructs dimensions and measures

Measures used in this paper are consistent with the established theory base in this stream of research, and are closely aligned to the constructs being investigated. Linkages between the relevant concepts, constructs, dimensions and measures have been established in previous studies and are given in Table I to support the choice of measures.

Methods

Using two independent sources of information, one for the dependent variables (DVs) (i.e. one to one supervisory ratings of managers’ performance) and the other for the independent variables (i.e. managers’ self-report measures of affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction) eliminated unnecessary noise in the data caused by common method variance.

Another distinctive contribution of this research was the use of canonical correlation and standard multiple regression to analyse the multifarious relationships between managers’ affective wellbeing, intrinsic job satisfaction and their contextual and task performance as detailed by Hosie *et al.* (2006). Canonical correlation is a “multivariate statistical model that facilitates the study of interrelationships among sets of multiple dependent variables and multiple independent variables” (Hair *et al.*, 1995, p. 444). For studies with multiple DVs and IVs, canonical correlation is the “most appropriate and powerful technique” (Hair *et al.*, 1995, p. 444). Canonical correlation is suitable for assessing the relationship between metric IVs and multiple dependent measures to ascertain the strength and the nature of the defined relationship (Hair *et al.*, 1995).

Multiple regression analysis is a statistical technique for analysing the relationships between a single dependent (criterion variable) and several predictor variables

Constructs	Dimensions	Measures
Positive affect Negative affect	Interested, distressed, excited, upset, strong, guilty, scared, hostile, enthusiastic, proud, irritable, alert, ashamed, inspired, nervous, determined, attentive, jittery, active and afraid	20-item positive and negative affect schedule, Watson and Clark (1984)
Enthusiasm, depression, anxiety, relaxation	Gloomy, calm, anxious, enthusiastic, motivated, worried, restless, tense, depressed, optimistic, relaxed and miserable	12-item four factor model of affective wellbeing, Sevastos (1996) and Warr (1990)
Intrinsic job satisfaction	Utilisation of skills, amount of job complexity and opportunities for control, amount of responsibility and challenges	7-item subscale, Cook <i>et al.</i> (1981)
Managers' contextual performance	Persisting, volunteering, helping, following and endorsing	Author devised 22-item scale of managers' contextual performance developed from Borman and Motowidlo's (1997) five-dimension taxonomy. Items from Konovsky and Organ (1996), Organ and Lingl (1995), Borman and Brush (1993) and Podsakoff <i>et al.</i> (1990)
Managers' task performance	Planning, guiding, training, communicating, representing, technical, administrating, maintaining, coordinating, deciding, staffing, persisting, stressing, committing, monitoring, delegating, influencing, interpreting, organisational effectiveness	Author devised 75-item scale of managers' task performance developed from Borman and Brush (1993) 18-dimension taxonomy. Subscale items developed to measure “Judgement” Cialdini (1993), Mintzberg (1980, 2004) and “Organisational effectiveness” Quinn <i>et al.</i> (1996)

Table I.
Concepts, constructs, dimensions and measures

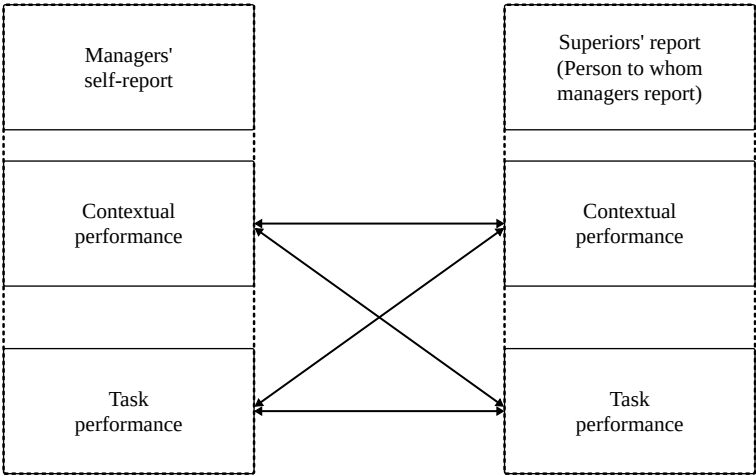
(Hair *et al.*, 1995). The regression analysis procedure ensures the maximum prediction from the set of IVs by weighting each IV. Standard multiple regression was used on the predictor variables to test the specified hypotheses. Standard multiple regression analysis is used to predict DVs from the knowledge of one or more IVs (Tabachnick and Fidell, 2001).

A unique methodology was used to develop the measurement model of managers' performance (“Measurement Model”) depicted in Figure 2. Advanced statistical techniques are used to analyse these important managerial issues by measuring the substance and structure of job performance to a standard previously unachievable. Testing of the measurement model, included exploratory and confirmatory factor analysis (CFA), multigroup analyses and accounting for the biasing effect of method.

Development of managers' performance measurement instrument

Before addressing the potential links arising from the literature between managers' job performance, it was critical to establish the structure of managers' performance. Defining and measuring managers' performance in order to devise a model that could

Figure 2.
Measurement model of
managers' performance



be operationalised in other organisations was a major aim of this paper. To achieve this outcome it was necessary to test the measurement properties of the managers' performance scales in different contexts.

Managers' self-reported items were used to develop the exploratory factor analysis (EFA) structure of managers' performance. Both subsamples of managers' self-report and superiors' ratings were used to confirm the measurement model. The factor structure of the measurement instrument was examined using EFA and CFA on data obtained from the samples. CFA was conducted to test hypotheses in order to establish the measurement model. Applying these analyses to different samples was done to evaluate the robustness of the measurement model. Testing the invariance of the measurement model was examined using CFA to establish that the dimensionality of the performance construct was equivalent across manager and superior ratings.

Based on this data a multitrait-multimethod (MTMM) analysis was used to test the methodological *H3* to establish whether there is evidence of methods effects and response bias. Figure 2 gives a schematic representation of managers' performance using MTMM to represent the evaluation relationships. MTMM is a technique for testing the construct validity of hypotheses using multiple traits and multiple methods (Byrne, 1994). Construct validity of managers' ratings on contextual and task performance are established by MTMM on the evidence of convergent validity, methods effects, and discriminant validity (Byrne, 1994; Campbell and Fiske, 1959).

Hypotheses on the construct of managers' performance

This section deals with how the methodological hypotheses, in addition to the hypotheses described in were derived from the literature relating to managers' performance. These hypotheses were developed and tested in order to establish the structure, the most reliable indicators, and the shared meaning attributable to dimensions of managers' contextual and task performance. Factors need to be established to indicate the dimensions of performance. These hypotheses also tested whether the construct "managers' performance" can be generalised across groups, beginning with *H1*:

- H1.* Task performance and contextual performance are distinct measures and generalizable across different groups that is, managers' and superiors' contextual and task performance will remain invariant when compared across groups.

Superiors are likely to consider both in-role (task) and extra-role (contextual) behaviours when rating managers' performance. Contextual performance may enhance managerial performance and be positively related to the quantity and quality of managers' performance. Borman and Motowidlo (1997) have argued that the contextual performance domain is conceptually distinct from components of task performance, and so may be measured separately. Conway (1996) found support for the existence of contextual and task performance dimensions using CFA and a multitrait-multirater database. Task performance is role prescribed, while contextual performance is typically discretionary (Katz and Kahn, 1978). However, the distinction between them has yet to be directly empirically tested for managers (Motowidlo and van Scotter, 1994). The independence of contextual and task performance needs to be distinguished to establish if both contribute independently to managers' performance. This leads to the *H1* of the managers' measurement model:

- H2.1.* Managers and their superiors will perceive the same dimensions of performance, in terms of pattern relationships; loadings; and covariances.

Studies of the job activities of managers by Luthans *et al.* (1988), revealed that traditional activities – planning, coordinating, decision-making, controlling and monitoring performance – were rated as most important by managers. Jansen and Stoop (1997) confirmed and extended these findings. Additionally, planning and coordinating activities, as well as the non-traditional network of activities, were correlated with managerial success (Jansen and Stoop, 1997). Both studies relied solely on managers' self-report of their job activities. However, perceptions of other actors, such as superiors, are important in constructing accurate ratings of managers' performance.

Bommer *et al.* (1995) recommended that future research address the appropriate dimensionality of employee performance. Borman and Motowidlo (1993) found superiors consistently weigh the contextual performance of subordinates approximately the same as task performance. For this proposition to hold, managers' superiors should assess managers' contextual performance as contributing the equivalent amount of variance to overall job performance as task performance. Contextual performance may be positively related to the quantity and quality of managers' performance. An association across managers' and their superiors' perceptions, on the same dimensions of contextual and task performance, needs to be established, leading to the next hypothesis:

- H2.2.* A multi-dimensional construct of performance will fit the data better than either a unidimensional construct of performance, or a two-dimensional construct (contextual and task performance).

Managers' rated performance has traditionally been conceived as a unidimensional construct. Conceptualisation of the job performance domain is being expanded (Arvey and Murphy, 1998). It remains to be established if managers' performance is a multivariate construct as stated in *H2.2*:

H3. Managers will rate their contextual and task performance less accurately compared to the person to whom they report (superiors).

Fundamentally, attribution error is the tendency to over-attribute behaviour to internal rather than to external causes (George and Jones, 1996; Heider, 1958). Managers are likely to attribute the behaviour of others to internal causes and their own behaviour to external causes (de Vader *et al.*, 1986; Jones and Nisbett, 1972). In these circumstances, managers' superiors are likely to attribute good performance to environmental factors and poor performance to a person's character (George and Jones, 1996). Conversely, supervisors and peers attribute others' good performance to environmental factors and poor performance to a person's disposition (de Vader *et al.*, 1986; Jones and Nisbett, 1972).

Warr reminded us that:

[...] most studies of work performance have been based upon ratings by superiors or peers. These ratings tend to be rather crude, and may be subject to a number of biases (Warr, 1987, p. 293).

Studies that have used self-ratings of contextual performance, in conjunction with self-reports of dispositional and attitudinal variables, generally result in spuriously high correlations amongst performance variables that are confounded by common method variance (Organ and Ryan, 1995). Supervisory ratings of job performance neglect to report correlations among self-raters (Barrick and Mount, 1991; Judge *et al.*, 2001).

Crampton and Wagner (1994) have argued that inflated ratings caused by self-report varies according to the domain of research – an issue that warrants empirical testing and verification in the case of managers' contextual performance. The veracity of managers' ratings of contextual and task performance have yet to be empirically demonstrated. It is still to be established if contextual performance is best measured by other or self-ratings (Organ and Ryan, 1995). A meta-analysis by Bommer *et al.* (1995) concluded that objective and subjective measures of employees' performance should not be used interchangeably.

Summary: measurement model of managers' job performance

Of particular importance was the development and testing of the measurement model. An eight-dimensional measurement model, derived from the contemporary literature, was tested to differentiate the structure of managers' contextual and task performance. The job performance construct was found to consist of four contextual dimensions (endorsing, supporting and defending organisational objectives; helping and cooperating with others; persisting with enthusiasm and extra effort to complete task activities successfully; following organisational rules and procedures) and four task dimensions (monitoring and controlling resources; technical proficiency; influencing others; and delegating to others).

Hypotheses on affective wellbeing, intrinsic job satisfaction and managers' performance

A number of gaps arise from the literature about affective wellbeing, intrinsic job satisfaction and managers' performance that are worthy of investigation. These were developed into a series of hypotheses for testing as described in the following:

H4. Affective wellbeing, as rated by their superiors, is associated with managers’ contextual and task performance.

Ability aside, managers with high affective wellbeing would be expected to perform better than those with less affective wellbeing (Campbell, 1991). People in higher-level jobs report significantly less job-related depression-enthusiasm than workers in lower-level jobs, but also significantly more job-related anxiety-contentment (Birdi *et al.*, 1995; Warr, 1990, 1994; Warr *et al.*, 1979). Affective states are posited to translate into behavioural outcomes that would affect employees performance (Staw and Barsade, 1993).

Highly motivated managers who desire challenges may react to risks in a way that raises anxiety but does not negatively impact on their affective wellbeing. High-performing managers are likely to experience periods of heightened anxiety, followed by periods of relaxation, yet maintain an overall sense of positive affective wellbeing.

In relation to work adjustment theory, Warr concluded that; “it seems probable that the contribution of job-related affective wellbeing to performance will arise primarily at low levels of affective wellbeing” (Warr in Hesketh, 1993, p. 151). Wright and his colleagues were unable to establish a relationship between dispositional affect as a predictor of supervisor-rated job performance (Wright *et al.*, 2002; Wright *et al.*, 2002; Wright and Staw, 1999b):

H5. Components of affective wellbeing are differentially associated with contextual performance and task performance.

Both theory (George and Brief, 1996) and empirical evidence (Isen and Baron, 1991) indicate that positive affect (PA) is related to employee motivation. A positive disposition may result in successful performance involving helping behaviours. People tend to be more attracted to those who have a positive rather than a negative demeanour, and are therefore more likely to receive higher performance ratings. Individuals exhibiting PA are also more likely to receive social support (Caplan *et al.*, 1975; McGovern *et al.*, 1978), be invited to join supervisory cliques (Graen, 1976), be selected for prestigious positions (McGovern *et al.*, 1978; Rasmussen, 1984), appear more energised (Staw and Barsade, 1993), and be positively assessed by others (Cardy and Dobbins, 1986; Krzystofiak *et al.*, 1988). Managers demonstrating PA may also be more successful in organisations because of adept interpersonal skills (Wright and Staw, 1999a, b).

Managerial work involves decision making, often with ambiguous and incomplete information, which would be expected to influence affective states (Mintzberg, 1973). Managers perform multifarious roles requiring working with employees, supervising others, participating in meetings and liaising with external constituents. These aspects of managerial work were shown by Staw and Barsade (1993) to impact on the performance of interpersonal responsibilities and decision making.

Sevastos’s (1996) four factor model of job-related wellbeing indicated that employees can experience high arousal and relaxation at separate times. When the duration and frequency of managers’ performance are punctuated by intermittent experiences of low affective wellbeing, this may increase tension and anxiety. In such situations, impairment of managers’ affective wellbeing may be experienced over a period of time.

This line of reasoning can possibly be extended to establish whether high-performing managers, who constantly experience periods of high anxiety, will also experience depression. In these circumstances, extended periods of anxiety may

not lead to a demise in affective wellbeing. As such, it is worth testing whether experiencing anxiety leads to depression, when intrinsic job satisfaction is high. Enthusiastic behaviour (high levels of arousal) is posited to be associated with superior performance, while depression (low levels of arousal and hence boredom) is likely to be associated with poor performance. This highlights a research proposition suitable for further examination, that is, people in managerial level jobs will report significantly less job-related depression than anxiety (Birdi *et al.*, 1995; Warr, 1990):

- H6. There is a positive association between managers' enthusiasm and contextual performance, as rated by their superior.

Managers must interact with others to get policies approved and implemented and procure resources to achieve organisational goals. Individuals with positive affective wellbeing are likely to be more effective in circumstances requiring interpersonal persuasion and negotiation (Staw and Barsade, 1993). Contextual and task performance are likely to be determined by different predictors (Motowidlo and van Scotter, 1994).

Affective wellbeing may be more conceptually aligned with contextual rather than task performance. Affective variables, such as job satisfaction and mood have been found to be causally related to contextual performance behaviours, involving cooperating and helping others (Bateman and Organ, 1983; Motowidlo *et al.*, 1986; Organ and Konovsky, 1989; Organ and Lingl, 1995). A link is yet to be established between managers' affective wellbeing and contextual performance. Managers reporting elevated levels of enthusiasm may receive higher contextual performance ratings from the person to whom they report:

- H7. There is a negative association between managers' anxiety and task performance, as rated by their superior.

Perceived workload has been associated with anxiety (Warr, 1990). Consistent with Warr's (1992) findings, those in higher level jobs (e.g. managers) would be expected to report elevated anxiety. Even if experienced for extended periods, this may not indicate negative affect (NA) or low PA. For example, managers with high levels of motivation and risk-taking behaviour may experience raised anxiety and high performance. Managers may be psychologically healthy and also experience consistently high levels of anxiety as a response to a hostile environment. In this circumstance, lowered affective wellbeing is unlikely to occur. However, when the duration and frequency of anxiety is experienced over a period of time, it may lead to impairment in managers' task performance. This leads to a question requiring further examination: does constantly experiencing anxiety impact on managers' task performance?:

- H8. Enthusiasm and relaxation (pleasantness based affect) are stronger predictors of rated contextual performance than anxiety and depression (activation based affect), as rated by their superior.

Performance implications for negative emotions have been suggested to be more pronounced than for positive emotions and to "predict greater decrements in performance for negative emotional states than for positive states" (Weiss and Cropanzano, 1996, p. 55). Wright and Staw (1999a, p. 17) found that "Pleasantness-based dispositional affect was strongly predictive of performance evaluations ... whereas

activation-based affect did not predict rated performance". Wright and Staw (1999a, p. 19) suggested that, "research should now examine whether a syndrome exists in which dispositional affective wellbeing and performance are associated". Sevastos also categorised anxiety as a "strong arousal" (activation affect) affect and depression with "disengagement". This was at odds with Wright and Staw's predictions. Thus, the "happy-productive worker" thesis may hold when happiness is operationalised by a pleasantness-based measure of affect:

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H9. There is a positive association between managers' overall intrinsic job satisfaction and their rated contextual and task performance, as rated by their superior.

Lawler and Porter (1967) and Locke (1976) claimed that high-performance results in job satisfaction rather than the converse. There is some empirical evidence to suggest that "links between overall satisfaction and rated performance are stronger among professional and managerial samples than among blue-collar workers" (Warr, 1987, p. 293). However, these differences "seem likely to arise from different performance-reward contingencies in the two types of jobs", and this required further clarification (Warr, 1987, p. 293). Moreover, it is yet to be confirmed whether these findings can be applied to a discrete population of employees, such as managers.

The failure to establish a relationship between job satisfaction and performance may be a result of a narrow definition and operationalisation of job performance (Organ, 1988). A broader conceptualisation of job performance that includes contextual and task performance may lead to an increased correlation with the construct.

More recent research into the antecedents of job satisfaction has focused on broadening the theoretical base of causal factors affecting job satisfaction, including dispositional effects (Agho *et al.*, 1993; Judge and Hulin, 1993; Judge *et al.*, 1998). Also, it was more appropriate to use a more affective orientated (i.e. intrinsic) measure of job satisfaction. Judge *et al.* (2001) have also argued that reconsideration of a satisfaction-performance relationship was justified:

H10. Managers' affective wellbeing is positively associated with contextual performance, while managers' cognitions are positively associated with task performance, as rated by their superior.

The bulk of research has found personality to be associated with contextual performance (Borman and Motowidlo, 1997; Motowidlo *et al.*, 1997). A number of studies into the effects of disposition and personality as predictors of organisational citizenship behaviour (OCB) and contextual performance are predicated on the belief that mood stems from an individual's disposition (Organ, 1994; Penner *et al.*, 1997; Watson and Clark, 1984; Watson and Tellegen, 1985).

Focused personality constructs, which measured prosocial personality, have been found to predict enduring levels of OCB (Penner *et al.*, 1997). Motowidlo *et al.* (1997) predicted that contextual performance will be associated with personality variables, whereas task performance is associated with cognitive ability. Furthermore, they argue that task proficiency varies with the tasks being executed, and that knowledge, skills and abilities covary with task proficiency:

H11. Managers who report intrinsic job satisfaction and enthusiasm will have elevated relaxation, anxiety and low depression.

Sevastos (1996) found elevated enthusiasm and low depression to be more strongly related to intrinsic job satisfaction when compared to anxiety and relaxation. Also, job-related affect was strongly related to work pressure or job demands. In the job demand model, positive outcomes from an “active” job may potentially change into negative outcomes consistent with a “high-strain” job (i.e. job dissatisfaction) without any concomitant changes in the job features. According to the job strain model, enriched jobs are associated with job satisfaction and low depression.

Conversely, impoverished jobs will normally be associated with job dissatisfaction and depression. Higher job performance is predicted to be associated with high anxiety, while low job performance will ordinarily be associated with low anxiety. The contribution of affective wellbeing to job performance is likely to be most noticeable at very high or very low levels.

Findings

Figure 3 shows the partial model that was used to test the related hypotheses. The following association were found between the IVs (affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction) and the DVs (managers contextual and task performance).

Both the theoretical literature and empirical evidence indicate that PA and intrinsic job satisfaction lead to favourable job performance (Judge *et al.*, 2001). The direction of the relationship between the variables, reported in the literature, is from affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction to performance (Warr in Kahneman *et al.*, 1999, p. 593). Therefore, the direction of the relationship to be tested in the partial model will be from affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction, to managers’ contextual and task performance, but this does not infer causality. Other commentators (Côté, 1999) have concluded that there is a bidirectional causal relation between pleasant affect and strong job performance.

Managers’ self-report of affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction was related to superiors’ ratings (i.e. downward) of managers’ performance to ensure the independence of the measures. Specific indicators of affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction were found to be reliable predictors of certain dimensions of managers’ performance. PA and

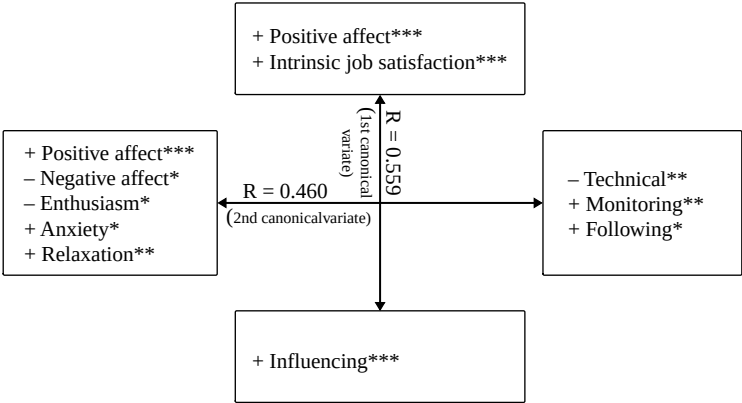


Figure 3.
A partial model of managers’ affective wellbeing, intrinsic job satisfaction and performance (“partial model”)

Note: * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$

intrinsic job satisfaction was found to be positively associated with a dimension of superiors' report on task performance (influencing) as indicated in Figure 4.

PA is a personality trait characteristic associated with extraversion, a personality characteristic that is central to managerial jobs in dealing with peers, superiors, subordinates and external constituents. PA is an "activation based" affect which enables managers to influence decisions from which they derive considerable intrinsic job satisfaction, which has a substantial cognitive component. Possibly, the opportunity to influence decisions within an organisation may also result in enhanced intrinsic job satisfaction and heightened affective wellbeing. Thus, managers who have elevated PA and intrinsic job satisfaction are more likely to influence decisions.

A more complex relationship was found between other indicators of affective wellbeing, intrinsic job satisfaction and performance. Positive associations between dimensions of self-report for affective wellbeing (PA, anxiety and relaxation) were found to be negatively associated with dimensions of superiors' reports on managers' task performance (monitoring) and contextual performance (following). NA and enthusiasm were negatively associated with the performance variable technical but positively associated with monitoring and following. This indicated that high arousal (PA with NA) was present, but these administrative job tasks were not found to be particularly motivating, as indicated by negative enthusiasm but positive relaxation. This finding indicates that managers will experience a degree of arousal but low distress when undertaking administrative or transactional roles. Managers with high PA are likely to experience elevated anxiety but have opportunities for relaxation that lead to acceptable levels of affective wellbeing when undertaking work involving monitoring and following.

An alternative explanation for these associations may be that aspects of managers' jobs requiring essentially transactional or administrative roles (negative technical, with positive monitoring and following) may lead to high arousal with PA and anxiety, but provide opportunities for Relaxation in conjunction with negative enthusiasm and NA. A positive association with monitoring and following indicated that these performance characteristics require vigilance and consequently high arousal (anxiety and PA with the attendant NA), but do not lead to a motivating environment (negative enthusiasm).

Notably, managers reported PA, a personality trait, to be the only variable common to both dimensions of contextual and task performance, indicating that it is a

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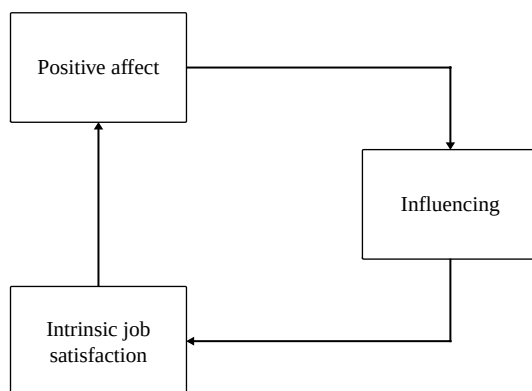


Figure 4.
Relationship between PA,
intrinsic job satisfaction
and influencing

prerequisite for managerial jobs. From this finding it could be inferred that successful managers will have a positive disposition to work. How do these findings relate to the working milieu managers' must contend with?

Someone keeps moving the goal posts

Pressures to manage within increasingly complex local, national and global workplace dynamics are greater than ever before. Restructuring, deregulation, tariff reductions, outsourcing, rapid uptake of technology and internationalisation are just some of the competitive forces that continue to drive organisations to intensify workplace productivity. Long working hours, necessitated by "downshifting" as organisations move from "lean to mean", are impacting on individual performance and organisational productivity from the "shop floor to the top floor". The consequence of these pressures is that fewer managers are doing considerably more work in an effort to maintain and improve organisational output.

Seismic shifts across all sectors of the workplace have led to a more insecure work environment where managers are expected to efficiently perform a wider range of complex functions. Increasingly, knowledge creation and the management of knowledge workers are a particularly challenging aspect of the ever expanding roles expected of managers. These unsettling and relentless changes to the work environment are having a major impact on managers at all levels in the workplace which are in turn flowing through to the employees. In combination, pressures for change and the propensity of organisations to maximise short-term financial and capital gain are impacting on the wellbeing of managers. Not surprisingly, this scenario is a potential source of considerable anguish for managers as well as for the organisations that rely on their performance. How do these developments relate to the emergence of the "happy-performing managers" proposition?

Successful organisations are dependent on managers who are capable of achieving and fully maintaining high levels of individual job performance. Individual and collective levels of managers' performance are therefore critical to the survival and prosperity of small and large-scale organisations alike. In this ultra competitive marketplace, the capacity of organisations to be productive and profitable is very reliant on managers creating a work environment where employees are fully engaged, contributing and committed.

Otherwise engaged

A negative outcome of ignoring managers' affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction is the alarming and counterproductive increase in actively disengaged and demotivated employees. Diminished performance resulting from disengaged employees is very costly to organisations. Attaining and sustaining the optimal individual and collective performance of employees in this dynamic environment is impacting on the happiness and performance of managers. The corollary of the problem of dealing with disengaged employees is contributing to the demise of managers' affective wellbeing.

Increased pressures to lift individual performance in organisations have reached critical mass. Managers are now expected to produce higher quality goods and services with fewer resources. The result of economic rationalisation and globalisation is directly attributable to the high incidence of stress, burnout and depression amongst employees

and managers. These dramatic and ongoing changes to the macro economic environment have driven substantial changes in managers' roles and their performance.

The next sections explain why these findings are relevant to managers and the organisations they work in.

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“Squeezing the pips”

As mentioned earlier, organisations are under increasing pressure to improve productivity while simultaneously reducing costs. This situation has resulted in an epidemic of “corporate anorexia” (Hamel, 1996). An enterprise formula is emerged – “ $1/2 \times 2 \times 3$ ” – whereby half as many people are being paid twice as much, to produce three times more (Handy, 1996). This trend to “squeezing the pips” is particularly evident for managers, where the incidence of stress and burnout is increasingly common (Quinn *et al.*, 1996; Reinhold, 1997). An incessant drive by organisations to cut costs and downsize has resulted in fewer people undertaking more work. There is also a pervasive sense of unease about the lack of job tenure.

Organisational dynamics experienced by Australian managers, who comprised the dataset for this paper, are similar to those facing managers in many other nation-states. Australian managers are under increasing pressure to produce superior results in shorter time-frames, with fewer resources (Forster and Still, 2001). Handy (1996) considered the “ $1/2 \times 2 \times 3$ ” formula “about right” for the work environment in Australia, New Zealand, the UK and North America. These findings are likely to apply to managers in developed capitalist countries. To reach and sustain heightened levels of performance and to avoid burnout in this environment, it is desirable that organisations develop strategies for maintaining managers' affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction. Of the three psychological aspects of burnout (emotional exhaustion, depersonalisation, diminished sense of personal accomplishment), emotional exhaustion is becoming increasingly prevalent in workplaces (Lee and Ashforth, 1996).

The rapid adoption of information technology has also accelerated the pace of work and increased role expectations. Ease of access to the Internet has exacerbated the demand for a “24/7” (24 hour, seven days a week) work culture that requires immediacy of responses to management and customers demands (Kenny and Cooper, 2003). This development needs to be seen as a part of the movement to team-based work becoming more widespread, downsizing forcing employees to exert more effort, pressures to deliver results in shorter time frames, customer service being emphasised and “fields of work” replacing specific “jobs” (Borman and Motowidlo, 1997). In all, a number of countervailing forces are apparent as, “Organizations are becoming more flexible, participative and simultaneously tougher and more humane” (Stone, 2002, p. 330). These rapid changes to the working environment will eventually impact on the levels of affective well-being experienced by managers and this is deleterious to long-term performance.

Implications for HRM

This paper investigated affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction and was intended to contribute to the broader debate over what underpins human performance at work. A more sophisticated understanding of how affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction interacts with managers' performance, contributes to a better comprehension of aspects of the relationships underlying these constructs. Evidence of how affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction interacts with managers'

performance will be valuable in determining job designs and organisational level interventions. Factors that are associated with how managers sustain heightened levels of performance are identified in the partial model (Figure 4). Such an understanding has the potential to translate into improved managerial practices. These findings are also intended to progress the wider debate about how work might be structured to improve employees' performance.

Successful initiatives to improve managers' affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction depend on individual and situational contingencies. Contingency theory indicates that one general intervention is unlikely to be effective for all managers in all situations, combinations of approaches are likely to result in longer term benefits. Therefore, the normal HR policies focussing on and trying to enforce control, conformity and standardisation across organisational departments is in conflict with these findings. Further, Mitchell (1979, p. 246) reported that:

[...] people who are high in achievement needs or growth needs respond more favourably (are more satisfied, happier and perform better) when faced with enhanced, challenging jobs than do people low in these needs.

In isolation, job enrichment may only enhance motivation for those managers who desire autonomy and challenge at work and in organisations where executives support participative decision making. Challenges and responsibility have been found to be the most important drivers of satisfaction in the contemporary workplace (Florida, 2003).

Assessments of affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction need to closely match the work environment that a manager is located in, a general consideration frequently overlooked, according to Warr (1987). Managers who spend long periods in jobs that lack opportunities for control and skill use are likely to have a NA on job-related competence. However, in some cases job-related anxiety, when linked to aspirations, is not necessarily linked to diminished affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction. For example, highly motivated managers who desire challenges may react to risks in a way that raises their anxiety level, but does not negatively impact their affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction.

The partial model identified some of the factors that indicate how managers attain and sustain heightened levels of performance. This research lends qualified support to the proposition that happy managers perform better. In turn, this helps to explain the process of upward and downward spirals of managerial effectiveness, whereby positive or negative affective wellbeing (enthusiasm, anxiety and relaxation) and intrinsic job satisfaction lead to increased or reduced performance. These in turn either enhance positive, or exacerbate negative affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction. These issues need to be addressed if organisations are to operate effectively in an integrative manner. Inappropriate and uncoordinated initiatives to improve managers' affective wellbeing, intrinsic job satisfaction and performance may result in costly and ineffectual outcomes for organisations.

Managers' jobs are likely to increase in complexity in the future, and as a consequence far more demanding. A deregulated global marketplace is likely to result in increased outsourcing. In this scenario, managers' roles are likely to evolve more into managing the outsourcing of organisations' needs rather than just managing people. Technological developments and movements to deregulation are exacerbating the speed and spread of this trend. As such, these trends in the marketplace are likely to

have a significant impact on managers' personal operating styles, making contextual performance an area warranting particular attention.

"Soft" and "hard" management forces

It is yet to be established if there is a mutual contribution (to performance?) of "soft" (people-driven human resource features, such as affective wellbeing, motivation and leadership) and "hard" (market-driven forces such as strategy formulation and program evaluation), aspects of management. By integrating "soft" or less tangible aspects of managers' performance, with "hard" aspects of management, this research explored how affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction of managers are relevant to the attainment of personal and organisational performance outcomes. Hence, the soft aspects of managers' performance may be associated with hard organisational outcomes, such that these:

[...] two apparently disparate approaches are not necessarily mutually exclusive. They can be reconciled through a contingency framework, which provides guidance on the positioning of an organization's human resource strategies as part of the organization's overall change strategy and ultimately its business strategy (Dunphy and Stace, 1990, p. 87).

However, the mutual contribution of "soft" (people-driven human resource features, such as motivation and leadership), and "hard" (market-driven forces such as strategy formulation and program evaluation) aspects of management have yet to be established (Nankervis *et al.*, 2004). However, evidence is emerging to indicate that management practices designed to humanise the workplace are being reciprocated by improved productivity (Maister, 2001).

Many studies have confirmed that so-called soft skills are critical for a vital economy (Boyatzis, 1982; Carnevale *et al.*, 1988; Spencer *et al.*, 1997; US Department of Labor, 1991). Management occurs within the complex milieu of organisations, entities riddled with messy challenges. Dealing with these intractable problems requires a fundamentally "soft" approach that is dependent on the imprecise, but fundamental notions, of intuition, wisdom and judgement (Mintzberg, 2004). In this situation, affective wellbeing and contextual performance may be seen as conceptually aligned and mutually reinforcing.

Management may be characterised as "mostly soft stuff – working with people, doing deals, processing vague information, and so forth" (Mintzberg, 2004). These various stages of the decision-making process are seen by Mintzberg as essentially soft in nature. Managers must be able to make judgement calls by identifying the issues, diagnosing their character, conceiving of and locating choices, and seeing the solution through to its logical conclusion. These various stages of the decision-making process are seen by Mintzberg as essentially soft in nature.

Individual task performance only captures a portion of what managers contribute to organisations. This portion is mainly attributed to the knowledge, skills, abilities and experiences of managers. In addition, performance is part of this iterative system. Performance is not simply an outcome but is also an input into other variables. As such, performance is not independent as all DVs impact iteratively on each other. Contributions beyond task and contextual performance may be more accurately termed as discretionary behaviour. These behaviours contribute to organisational effectiveness and go beyond "soft" psychology, or "humanistic" concerns to become a critical part of the managers' contribution. As Cohen (2005, p. 44) says, "We need to rethink the whole

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area of corporate education and become more humanistic". Unfortunately, as Barnard (1938, p. 5) observed, "successful cooperation in, or by formal organisations, is the abnormal, not normal condition", so:

[...] perhaps the reason for the dearth of explanatory power of the "softer" side of I/O psychology in the study of performance has not been because it is too soft, but that our dependent variable, "performance", has been too hard (Organ and Paine, 1999, p. 338).

Integrating the soft and hard aspects of organisational existence has the potential to improve the interconnections between management disciplines, as well as providing useful insights for related fields (Staw, 1986). Hard control in management can be repulsed with soft control as well as self-discipline emanating from individual empowerment and individual autonomy. Soft skills, such as inspiring employees and generating commitment, are more difficult to master and sustain than the hard skills associated with strategic and operational business planning (Ulrich, 1997). Also, using soft skills does not come naturally to some managers. The statistical analyses of data used in this paper has demonstrated that, when considered holistically, the use of separate job-related affects in organisational research can enhance our understanding of the relationships between affective outcomes (soft) and aspect of managers' performance (hard) variables. This provides support for a differential application of human resource, rather than a uniform application and management policies and procedures. Such an approach requires changes to some organisations policies and *modus operandi* away from command control and conformity to differential application of human resource policies and practices.

Recruitment and selection

In this paper, PA and intrinsic job satisfaction were strongly associated with influencing. PA is a trait personality characteristic associated with extraversion, a personality characteristic that is central to managerial jobs in dealing with peers, superiors, subordinates and external constituents. This indicates that managers who exhibit high levels of PA and intrinsic job satisfaction may be effective at influencing others within and outside organisations. Executives with assignments that require extensive influencing may look to managers who exhibit or report high levels of PA and intrinsic job satisfaction which indicates they are highly engaged at work. PA incorporates a personality trait (extraversion) that may also be a more useful indicator of a competency for selection purposes than the literature currently indicates. However, this finding should be tempered with the caveat that competencies represent managers' potential to perform rather than actual observed performance. This reality needs to be tempered with the realisation that a person's affective tendencies can influence their likeability, likelihood of being hired and the evaluation of their performance (Cook *et al.*, 2000).

An engaging personality may be a reason individuals are promoted or self-select into managerial positions. PA may enable managers to influence decisions from which they derive considerable intrinsic job satisfaction, which incorporates a substantial cognitive component. A positive outlook is indicated by a personal belief in the future which is a trait associated with greater resilience (Park, 2005). Possibly the opportunity to influence decisions within an organisation may result in enhanced intrinsic job satisfaction in addition to heightened PA. Also, it was shown that PA was the only variable common to both dimensions of contextual and task performance, indicating that it could be a useful aspect for managerial jobs.

Conclusions on the “happy-productive worker” thesis

Despite mixed empirical evidence, there is support in the literature to suggest that a relationship exists between employees’ affective wellbeing and their performance. Wright and Staw (1999a) claimed that a person’s disposition towards happiness, not organisational conditions, was associated with performance. Ledford (1999) extended this reasoning by concluding that if “only trait-based happiness leads to performance, it was pointless to try to make employees happier as a way of improving performance.” This position assumes that employees are either born happy or unhappy, and that such a demeanour would not change, notwithstanding the design of a job. There is, however, a vast literature exists to indicate that trait affect is not solely determined by hereditary, as approximately 50 per cent is determined by other factors (Broadbent, 1985; Gardner and Cummings, 1988; Gerhart, 1987; Hackman and Oldham, 1980; Hackman and Oldham, 1975; Ilgen and Hollenbrook, 1991).

This implies that that 50 per cent of personality traits has a genetic basis. Studies on many thousands of twins indicate that personality traits are based on 50 per cent of genetic differences (Benjamin *et al.*, 2001). Trait based personality characteristics are a general propensity to apply or perceive situations from the trait, for example, happy or introverted. Thus, changing a trait based NA or PA, including “happiness” can be difficult as this is an integral part of a person’s outlook, personality or perception of life events. For example, a person with a trait high in “suspicion” will perceive events via this “lens”. Conversely, a person with a high-optimism trait will perceive events via this “lens”. Changing traits is therefore not easy as they develop in the milieu of genetic, psychological and social factors such as emotions, behavioural and cognitive processes all interacting in a complex environment, including culture which results in complex human behaviour. Traits tend to be stable over the life span of the individual. All this points to the need for human resource policies and practices to determine which traits are most applicable to an organisation’s culture and the required contextual and task performance. This paper indicates the type of factors that can be used to help select managers who fit the organisation’s performance requirements.

PA was the only variable to be significantly associated with both task and performance dimensions. This indicated that managers with high PA were likely to perform well when influencing, and when undertaking monitoring and following roles, supporting the argument that managers’ with dispositional PA will outperform those who are unhappy (negative PA). This paper supports Wright and Staw’s (1999a) claim that a person’s disposition is associated with performance. However, this position should not be taken as evidence to support the Wright and Staw’s contention that organisational conditions do not influence the happiness of managers. A person’s genetic makeup, socialisation and life experiences all contribute to happiness.

Magnitude of mental health problems in the workplace

Organisations that do not take care of workplace happiness ultimately experience diminished individual performance. Over the last decade, mental health problems in the workplace have increased substantially for both industry and government. Approximately, one in ten employees is estimated to be suffering from depression, anxiety, stress or burnout in Australia, the European Union, the USA and Canada. Some 3-4 per cent of GNP worldwide is estimated to be expended on mental health

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problems in the workplace, which are rapidly becoming the most common reasons for allocating disability pensions and for people opting to retire early.

By 2020, it is estimated that depression will be the most common health problem in the workplace. In addition to workers' compensation claims, employers who fail to address workplace mental illness can expect to pay increased higher compensation and insurance premiums. Other problems in the workplace resulting from neglecting to look after managers' affective wellbeing are: disengagement, absenteeism, higher staff turnover, higher accident rates, reduced productivity and morale.

International estimates of the cost of depleted mental health show a consistent and disturbing trend. The incidence of mental health problems in the workplace is an issue that has reached alarming proportions. The resultant cost to organisations and nation-states is unacceptably high and is increasing exponentially. This has led governments in developed countries to begin to legislate to force organisations to accept the consequence of inappropriate management decisions on employee health. Deteriorations in managers' affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction can lead to disillusionment and burnout, which is likely to result in severe reductions in individual job performance.

All this bad news about diminished mental health in the workplace needs to be countervailed by good news. Evidence of this can be found in a new movement rapidly taking hold – positive organisational scholarship (POS).

POS – putting the head back on the body

The last decade has seen a growing movement in psychology to abandon the exclusive focus on the dark side of human existence with a preference to explore a more positive view of the mind. This paper contributes to the emerging movement of POS; a health model based on the premise that understanding and enabling human potential will create a positive path to human and organisational wellbeing.

There are sound social and economic reasons for promoting happiness through healthy workplace practices. Numerous studies have shown that happy people are successful in many aspects of life, including friendship, marriage, income, health and job performance. A link between happiness-success is evident where PA engenders success (Lyubomirsky *et al.*, 2005). In essence, the POS movement is metaphorically reattaching the head on to the body of organisational and occupational psychology. Likewise, this research confronts the challenge to explore new models, theories and ideas about managers' that contribute to enhancing affective wellbeing and performance in the workplace.

Pressures, strains and stresses on managers in the workplace have been identified as an important determinant of a person's mental health. Individual levels of affective wellbeing, intrinsic job satisfaction and performance have the potential to eventually impact on organisations' productivity. More importantly the personal cost of the demise in affective wellbeing to an individual's life is immense. An improved understanding of the way in which changes in affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction impact on performance will assist in identifying what can be done to promote a healthier and more productive work environment for managers.

Managers are in the front line of an ever shifting, difficult and dynamic business landscapes. Increased calls for efficiency gains, cost cutting and improved employee performance, including their own, require managers to simultaneously cope with workplace stress, fatigue and burnout. Managers seem to be unaware of the factors

that influence individual performance which results in organisational productivity. A better understanding of “performance levers” that managers should be pulling, and encouraging others to pull, to improve workplaces is needed.

Workplace problems attributed to “stress” may actually be symptoms of depression and anxiety. Job stress can lead to poor mental health. The terms stress, mental health and burnout are often used interchangeably in the literature. Stress and burnout are mainly used to describe work-related outcomes, while mental health may be context free. As a result, research on the construct of stress informs our understanding of affective wellbeing. Job satisfaction has also been found to be an important contributor to psychological health in the workplace.

Providing more rigorous measures of performance has the potential to guide the implementation of human resource development initiatives to improve individual managers’ performance. Timely feedback about affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction may assist organisations to monitor and implement changes to managers’ jobs in order to sustain and improve their performance. More refined assessments of performance may facilitate managers’ self-development, as they indicate what managers need to do in order to enhance their potential and to perform with sustainable effectiveness.

Insights in this research will make it possible to predict how deterioration or an improvement, in affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction impacts on managers’ performance. Management practices that increase managers’ affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction may result in corresponding reductions in workplace tension and improved efficiency. Evidence is disclosed on how affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction interact with managers’ performance will be valuable for determining job designs and organisational level interventions. Changes to the design of jobs can be enacted and embedded to enhance, or to avoid a decline in affective wellbeing, intrinsic job satisfaction and performance. Such an understanding has the potential to translate into improved managerial practices, which can impact on the performance of managers.

Conversely, this paper also shows how the individual consequences of diminished affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction can be disastrous. Diminished affective wellbeing will ultimately translate into the bottom line of organisational effectiveness, productivity, profitability and share prices. Such information may be used to develop interventions for promoting healthier and more supportive work environments. These findings are also intended to progress the debate as to how work might be structured to improve all employees’ performance.

Conclusion

Despite the mixed research findings of over half a century, there is support in the literature but scant empirical evidence to suggest that a link exists between happiness and job performance. A thorough re-assessment of the “happy-productive worker” thesis and transformation into the “happy-performing managers” proposition was undertaken by investigating the relationship between managers’ affective wellbeing, intrinsic job satisfaction and performance.

This paper has its origins in the enduring stream of management research into individual performance and organisational productivity. Contemporary and classic theories and models and research are employed to inform an age-old mystery in management – do happy workers, or in these cases managers, perform better, or worse,

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or does their affective state make no difference? The primary goal of this research was to establish which indicators of self-rated affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction are reliable indicators of managers' performance. Certain indicators of affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction are argued to predict dimensions of managers' job performance. An ancillary objective was to establish the structure of managers' performance. Development and testing of the model contributed to gaining an understanding of how affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction impact on managers' performance variables. Extrapolations were made from these findings and the interrelationships between the various interconnected disciplines, theories and models in the field. Implications of the research are of relevance to the body of management theory and practice.

Findings in this paper are intended to progress the debate as to how work might be structured to improve managers' affective wellbeing and performance. Managerial and practitioner recommendations are provided, followed by a close examination of the implications for strategic human resource management. A better understanding of how affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction influence managers' behaviour has the potential to enhance aspects of their performance.

Managers' performance was found to be multi-dimensional and consist of two components: contextual and task performance. Certain indicators of affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction were found to reliably predict dimensions of managers' contextual and task performance. A more sophisticated understanding of how the relationships between affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction interact with managers' performance has resulted in a better understanding of the "happy-performing managers" proposition.

There are many advantages to improving managerial practices in relation to affective wellbeing. Circumstances that might otherwise lead to a managers' dismissal or burnout may be less likely to arise if there is a means to identify managers "at risk". Such information can be used to assist in identifying defective organisational practices that have the potential to damage managerial affective wellbeing and intrinsic job satisfaction.

Interest in the "happy-performing managers" proposition can be seen within the broader context of the trend to POS. Insights from POS movement give cause for great optimism. POS has an affirmative bias towards the health model's capacity to discover and maintain ways that organisations can improve people's working lives. From this perspective, employee health and wellbeing are seen in terms of the presence of the potential for growth, optimism, contentment and actualisation – not simply as the absence of dysfunctional behaviour. The time has come to move away from the negative forms of psychology (based on a "deficit model") and affirm managers' future by embracing the "happy-performing managers" proposition.

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